

Project Management for Government Programmes

Planning, delivery, governance, risk, monitoring and benefits realisation

Level: Intermediate **Duration:** 6 hours

Complete Training Manual

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1. Course Overview

Develop practical project and programme controls for public-sector delivery with multiple stakeholders and formal accountability.

2. Learning Objectives

- Distinguish projects, programmes and operations.
- Translate outcomes into scope, deliverables and milestones.
- Build practical schedules and resource assumptions.
- Manage risks, issues, dependencies and changes.
- Use governance and dashboards for decisions.
- Close projects responsibly and sustain benefits.

3. Course Structure

Module	Focus	Time
1. Government Programme and Project Fundamentals	Distinguish projects, programmes and operations and frame initiatives around outcomes, scope and accountability.	60 min
2. Planning, Scheduling and Resource Management	Build realistic plans connecting activities, dependencies, resources and milestones.	60 min
3. Risk, Issue and Change Management	Anticipate uncertainty, manage active issues and govern scope changes.	60 min
4. Stakeholder, Vendor and Interdepartmental Coordination	Coordinate diverse actors and maintain accountability across departments and suppliers.	60 min
5. Monitoring, Quality, Benefits and Programme Controls	Use evidence to detect slippage, protect quality and connect delivery to outcomes.	60 min
6. Closure, Learning, Sustainability and Governance	Close responsibly, transfer ownership, capture learning and sustain benefits.	60 min

4. Government Programme and Project Fundamentals

Purpose: Distinguish projects, programmes and operations and frame initiatives around outcomes, scope and accountability.

Core topics

- Project vs programme vs operations
- Outcomes, outputs and benefits
- Project charter
- Scope boundaries
- Governance and decision rights

Practical activities

- Draft a project charter
- Separate outputs from outcomes
- Build a responsibility matrix

Expected outputs

- Project charter
- Outcome map
- RACI-style matrix

5. Planning, Scheduling and Resource Management

Purpose: Build realistic plans connecting activities, dependencies, resources and milestones.

Core topics

- Work breakdown structures
- Dependencies and critical path
- Milestones and baselines
- Resource planning
- Procurement dependencies

Practical activities

- Create a WBS
- Identify dependency chains
- Develop milestone and resource plans

Expected outputs

- WBS
- Schedule
- Resource plan

6. Risk, Issue and Change Management

Purpose: Anticipate uncertainty, manage active issues and govern scope changes.

Core topics

- Risk identification and scoring
- Owners and mitigation
- Issue logs and escalation
- Change requests and impact analysis
- Contingency planning

Practical activities

- Create a risk register
- Run a change-control scenario
- Design escalation thresholds

Expected outputs

- Risk register
- Issue log
- Change form

7. Stakeholder, Vendor and Interdepartmental Coordination

Purpose: Coordinate diverse actors and maintain accountability across departments and suppliers.

Core topics

- Stakeholder engagement
- Governance forums
- Vendor management
- Dependencies
- Meeting/action discipline

Practical activities

- Build engagement plan
- Design steering pack
- Create vendor review template

Expected outputs

- Stakeholder plan
- Steering pack
- Vendor review

8. Monitoring, Quality, Benefits and Programme Controls

Purpose: Use evidence to detect slippage, protect quality and connect delivery to outcomes.

Core topics

- KPIs and tolerances
- Quality assurance vs control
- Benefits tracking
- Earned-value concepts
- Dashboards and reviews

Practical activities

- Design a dashboard
- Create a benefits register
- Run a RAG review

Expected outputs

- Dashboard
- Benefits register
- Corrective-action plan

9. Closure, Learning, Sustainability and Governance

Purpose: Close responsibly, transfer ownership, capture learning and sustain benefits.

Core topics

- Acceptance and handover
- Records
- Post-implementation review
- Lessons learned
- Sustainability and exit criteria

Practical activities

- Draft closure criteria
- Run a post-implementation review
- Create a transition plan

Expected outputs

- Closure checklist
- Lessons report
- Transition plan

10. Integrated Public-Sector Case Study

A multi-department digital service programme has a fixed launch commitment. The vendor reports green, but field adoption is low, integration testing is incomplete, and requirements have changed.

Tasks

- Separate delivery metrics from programme outcomes.
- Identify top risks/issues and owners.
- Define governance decisions required before launch.
- Design a recovery dashboard with milestones, quality, adoption and benefits.

Debrief

- What evidence should challenge a green status?
- Which changes require impact assessment?
- How should launch readiness be defined beyond technical completion?

11. Assessment Bank

Multiple-choice questions

1. A programme is best understood as:

A. A single task B. Coordinated related projects managed for broader outcomes and benefits C. Only a procurement contract D. BAU activity

2. A WBS helps by:

A. Listing stakeholders B. Decomposing scope into manageable deliverables/work packages C. Removing dependencies D. Replacing governance

3. A risk differs from an issue because a risk is:

A. Always negative B. An uncertain event or condition that may affect objectives C. Already occurring D. A closed action

4. A risk owner is responsible for:

A. Ignoring risk B. Ensuring the risk is actively managed and responses followed C. Approving every expense D. Writing all reports

5. Change control exists mainly to:

A. Prevent all change B. Assess and govern impacts to scope, time, cost, quality or benefits C. Slow every decision D. Avoid stakeholder input

6. A milestone is:

A. A major scheduled point/event tracking progress B. A budget line C. A risk score D. A meeting invitation

7. Quality assurance focuses on:

A. Processes that prevent defects B. Only final inspection C. Increasing scope D. Reducing documentation

8. Benefits management asks:

A. Only whether tasks finished B. Whether intended outcomes and benefits are realised C. Whether meetings happened D. Which software was used

9. A baseline is useful because it:

A. Makes change impossible B. Provides an approved reference for comparing actual performance C. Eliminates risk D. Replaces forecasts

10. Closure should include:

A. Immediate disbanding B. Acceptance, documentation, ownership transfer and lessons C. Deleting records D. Stopping measurement

True / False

1. Every risk must have a mitigation that completely eliminates it.
2. Issues are active problems; risks concern uncertainty.
3. A project can be technically complete but fail to realise benefits.
4. Change requests should be assessed before approval.
5. A dashboard should contain every available metric.

Short-answer

1. Differentiate project, programme and operations.
2. What belongs in a risk register?
3. What is a milestone?
4. Why track benefits after outputs are delivered?
5. List five elements of a useful project status report.

Scenario questions

1. A vendor reports green but user acceptance testing is failing. What evidence and governance would you request?
2. A ministerial priority adds a major requirement two weeks before launch. How should the team process it?

Answer key

1. 1-B: programmes coordinate related work for broader outcomes.
2. 2-B: WBS decomposes approved scope.
3. 3-B: risk is uncertain; issue is current.
4. 4-B: ownership means active management.
5. 5-B: change control makes impacts explicit.
6. 6-A: milestone is a significant planned point.
7. 7-A: assurance improves process quality.
8. 8-B: benefits connect delivery to real-world results.
9. 9-B: baseline enables variance analysis.
10. 10-B: closure includes acceptance, handover and learning.
11. 11-False.
12. 12-True.
13. 13-True.
14. 14-True.
15. 15-False.

12. Final Assignment and Rubric

Create a complete project-management pack for a hypothetical government programme with a 6–12 month delivery horizon.

Components

- Project/programme charter and outcome map
- Scope statement and WBS
- Milestone schedule and dependencies
- Stakeholder and governance structure
- Risk and issue registers
- Change-control workflow
- Dashboard and benefits register
- Closure and transition plan

Criterion	Weight
Problem framing / objectives	20%
Method and execution plan	25%
Stakeholder / communication quality	20%
Risk, monitoring and governance	20%
Clarity and professionalism	15%

13. Glossary

Business as usual: Ongoing operational work not managed as a time-bounded project.

Programme: Coordinated management of related projects and activities for broader outcomes and benefits.

WBS: Hierarchical decomposition of approved scope into deliverables and work packages.

Baseline: Approved reference for comparing actual performance.

Risk register: Record of risks, causes, effects, likelihood, impact, owners and responses.

Issue: A problem or event that has already occurred and needs action.

Benefits register: Record of intended benefits, measures, owners, timing and evidence.

Change control: Formal process for evaluating, approving, rejecting and recording changes.

14. Quick Reference

- Mandate → outcomes → scope → deliverables → dependencies → schedule → resources → risks/issues → governance → monitoring → benefits → closure.
- Keep risks and issues separate.
- Every major risk needs an owner, response and review date.
- Challenge optimistic status when leading signals disagree.
- Assess changes for scope, time, cost, quality, security, compliance and benefits.
- Dashboards should support decisions, not display every metric.
- Success includes adoption and benefits, not only output delivery.

15. References and Verification Notes

UK Government, *Government Functional Standard GovS 002: Project Delivery*.
<https://www.gov.uk/government/publications/project-delivery-functional-standard>

OECD, public investment and project governance resources. <https://www.oecd.org/en/topics/public-investment.html>

UK Government, *Government Functional Standard GovS 001: Government Functions*.
<https://www.gov.uk/government/publications/government-functions-functional-standard>

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